



Int. Academy of Astronautics
SETI Committee



IAA SETI Committee Meeting

- All IAC participants interest in SETI are welcome!!!
- When? 1 October (Wednesday) 10.00-13.00
- Where ? Room E3.9

A Blueprint for Discovery...

Towards the 2026 SETI Declaration of Principles

Mike Garrett*, Kathryn Denning, Les Tennen & Carol Oliver
(IAA SETI Committee Post-Detection Task Group)

*Sir Bernard Lovell Chair of Astrophysics & Director of Jodrell Bank Centre for Astrophysics, University of Manchester, UK
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 - Information Sharing: How to notify the public, the scientific community, and global bodies like the UN.

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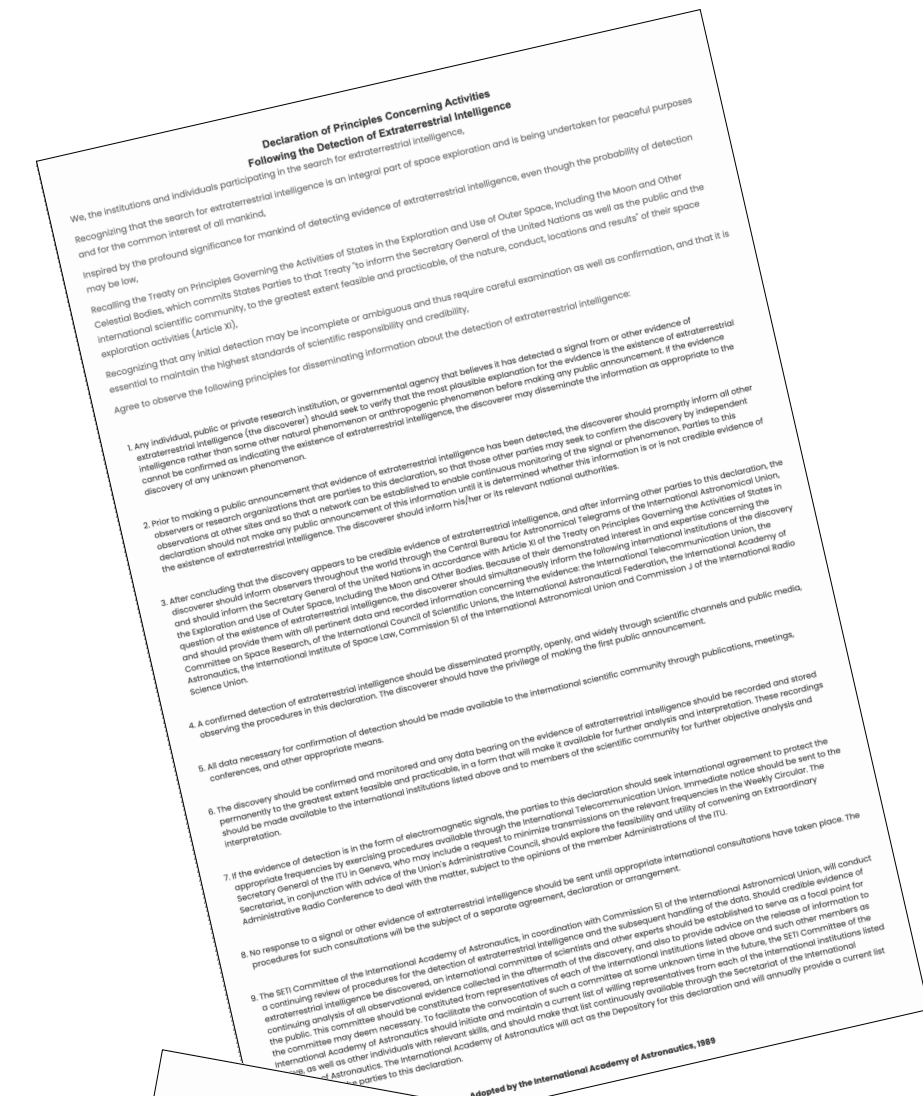
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 - Responding: The process for deciding whether humanity should send a reply to a confirmed signal.
 - Ethical and legal considerations: a commitment to global transparency, responsibility and adhering to the highest international standards.

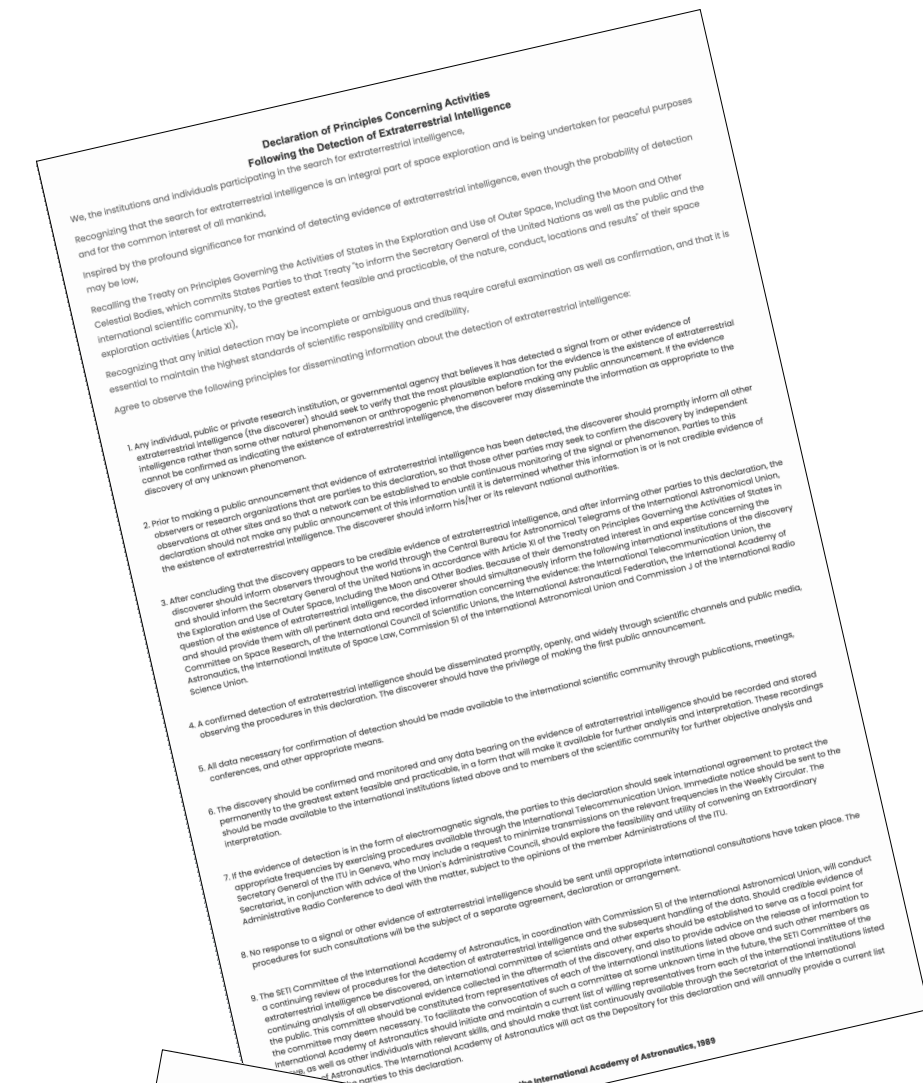
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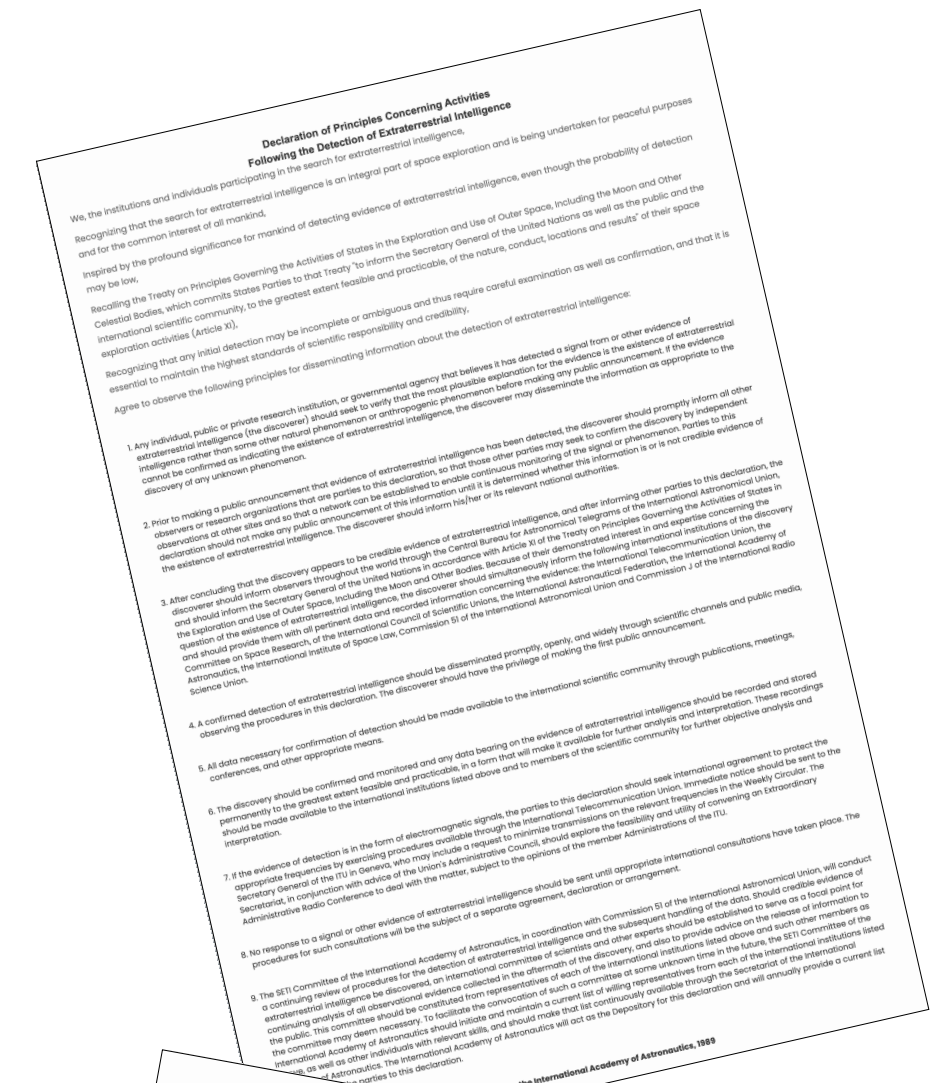
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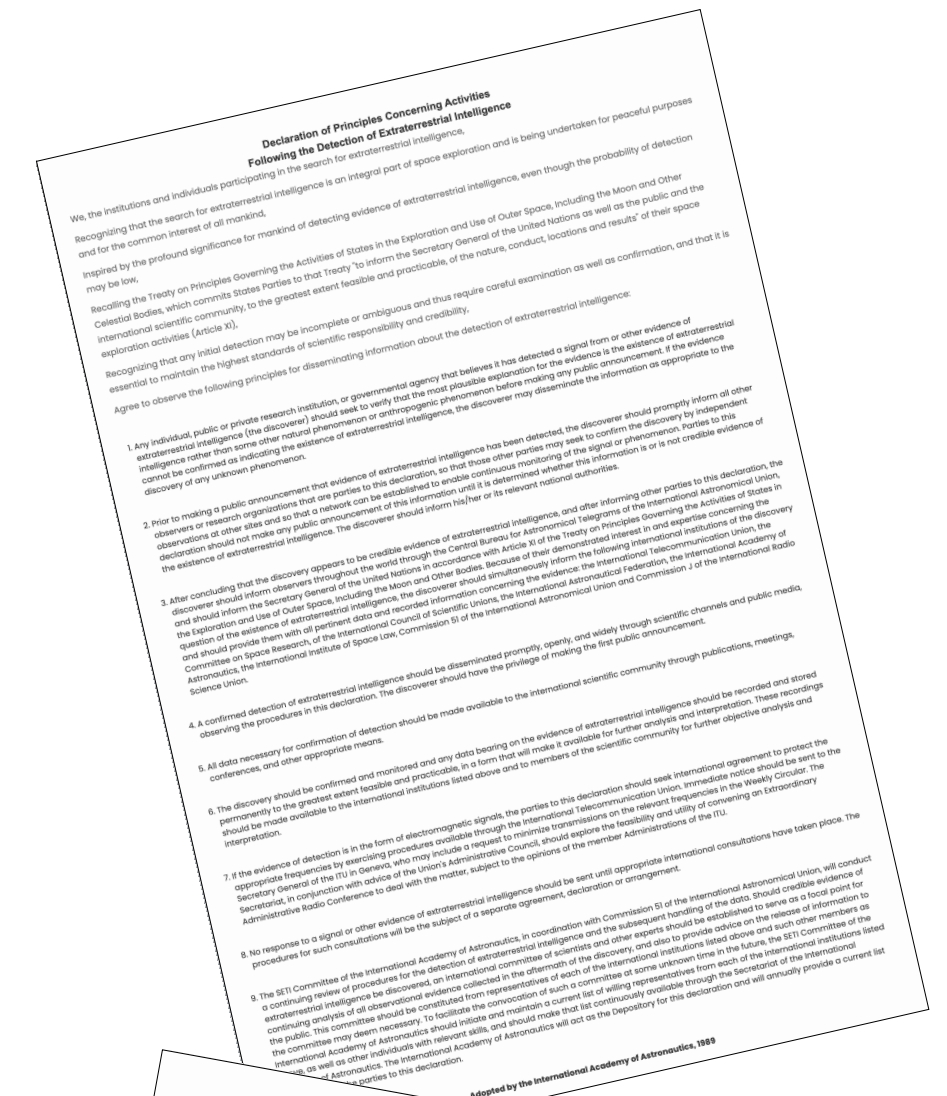
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- **A New Era:** An update is needed to address:
 - “Technosignatures” not just narrow-band radio signals...
 - The expansion of international participation in SETI.
 - The complexity of the global information environment.
 - Protection & safety of researchers.



The Journey: a multi-year process!

From Paris to Sydney:

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- **A2025 (IAC Sydney):** A new, near-final draft based on a structured consultation process.

**DRAFT REVISED Declaration of Principles Concerning the Conduct of the Search for
Extraterrestrial Intelligence (SETI) – 2026 Update
(version: 25 September 2025)**

Preamble

The International Academy of Astronautics SETI Committee has adopted these Principles to guide individuals, institutions, organisations, and other entities participating in the scientific Search for Extraterrestrial Intelligence (SETI), that is, the search based on astronomy and related disciplines for ‘technosignatures’¹ or evidence of past or present intelligent life and technology beyond Earth.

The purpose of this Declaration is to affirm our commitment to conduct the Search for Extraterrestrial Intelligence in a scientifically and academically rigorous manner; to establish best practices, principles and guidelines for scientists to confirm putative evidence of intelligent extraterrestrial beings; to provide guidance to the scientific community for the announcement of a confirmed SETI detection which balances the community imperative of providing timely and accurate information to a wide-ranging audience, with appropriate consideration for the safety and exposure of individual scientists involved; and to proactively inform the global public of these procedures and guidelines.

The commitments in this Declaration are made with the recognition that the scientific and communications landscapes are ever-changing, and this Declaration will be supplemented with Best Practices Guidelines, including guidance concerning safety for researchers, and a Code of Conduct that will be periodically re-examined and updated. This Declaration and any supplemental Guidelines and Codes will be placed on file with the International Academy of Astronautics (IAA) and made available on the IAA website.

Principles

1. Handling Candidate Evidence:

- In the event of a putative detection of extraterrestrial intelligence, the discoverer should endeavour to make all efforts to authenticate and substantiate the detection, using the resources available to the discoverer and in collaboration with other investigators. Such efforts should ideally include, but not be limited to, independent observations or other examinations by multiple facilities and by more than one organisation utilising different instrumentation and methods.
- Information about candidate signals or other potential detections should be handled with extreme care, recognising that initial findings may be incomplete or ambiguous, requiring thorough analysis and

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2. Communicating and Sharing Information:

- SETI practitioners and their institutions and organisations should be free to present reports on activities and results in public and professional fora. Individual practitioners shall have the right to decline from engaging directly or continually with the media, including social media, but shall use their best efforts to ensure that their organisation or institution provides updates on their science. Institutions and organisations should take appropriate steps for the safety of their researchers, and to protect them from negative professional repercussions.
- Institutions and organisations should be responsive to reasonable requests from news organisations, social media platforms, and other public communications media. Responses to inquiries should be prompt, accurate and honest.
- There is no obligation to disclose verification efforts until a discovery is confirmed. If a candidate technosignature is discovered, communication about ongoing observations and analyses may be necessary to dispel rumours and provide accurate and reliable information. Similarly, if analysis determines that a previously reported candidate technosignature is not extraterrestrial in origin, this should be promptly disclosed and clearly communicated.
- Speculative or unconfirmed statements and conclusions should be clearly identified as such.
- In their engagements with news and other media, institutions and organisations should provide accurate and timely information.

3. Communicating Verification:

- If the verification process satisfies Principle 1 and confirms – by the consensus of the other investigators involved and to a degree of certainty judged by the discoverers to be credible – that a signal or other evidence is due to extraterrestrial intelligence, the discoverers or their organisations or institutions should promptly report this conclusion in a full, complete and open manner to the public, the scientific community, and the Secretary General of the United Nations. The discoverers or their organisation or institution should have the privilege but not the obligation to make the first public announcement.
- The verification report should be peer-reviewed, and include the underlying data, the data analysis process and results of the verification efforts, any conclusions and interpretations, and any detected information content. This report should follow best practices in risk communication. The formal report should also be made to relevant organisations, including the International Academy of Astronautics, the International Astronomical Union, the Committee on Space Research (COSPAR) of the International Science Council, the International Institute of Space Law, the International Telecommunications Union, and the United Nations Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space, the Office of Outer Space Affairs, and other relevant U.N. bodies. Open access publication of verification data is encouraged.

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- The verification report should be peer-reviewed, and include the underlying data, the data analysis process and results of the verification efforts, any conclusions and interpretations, and any detected information content. This report should follow best practices in risk communication. The formal report should also be made to relevant organisations, including the International Academy of Astronautics, the International Astronomical Union, the Committee on Space Research (COSPAR) of the International Science Council, the International Institute of Space Law, the International Telecommunications Union, and the United Nations Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space, the Office of Outer Space Affairs, and other relevant U.N. bodies. Open access publication of verification data is encouraged.

4. Monitoring, Archiving and Data Accessibility

- All data bearing on the evidence of extraterrestrial intelligence, together with the data analysis methods and code, should be preserved and disseminated to the international scientific community through refereed journal publications, meetings, conferences, websites appropriate for long-term archiving, and other appropriate means.
- The discovery should be continuously monitored, and best practices for the safe, reliable, and resilient handling of data should be employed. All data bearing on the evidence of extraterrestrial intelligence including derived data products, should be recorded, and securely stored and archived to the greatest extent feasible and practicable, in at least two repositories in different geographic locations, and in a form that will make it accessible to observers and to the scientific community for replication of results and further analysis. The use of recognised international repositories and open standard formats is encouraged.

5. Data and Frequency Protection

- Evidence of detection should be protected utilising best scientific practices, including tamper-proof records and precautionary protocols. If the evidence of detection is in the form of electromagnetic signals international agreement should be sought to protect the appropriate frequencies by exercising the extraordinary procedures established within the International Telecommunication Union.

6. Post-Detection Protocol:

- The IAA SETI Committee will maintain a Post-Detection Sub-Committee to assist and advise in matters that may arise in the event of a confirmed detection, and to support the scientific and public analysis by offering guidance, interpretation, and discussion of the wider implications of the discovery. This subcommittee should include international representation with science, ethics, law, social sciences, and communications professionals, as well as communications researchers with expertise in science and risk communication.
- The SETI Committee Executive Officers will support and assist the Post-Detection Sub-Committee with engagements with social media platforms and news organisations to responsively and effectively aid in the dissemination of accurate and reliable information.
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- SETI practitioners shall adhere to the highest ethical standards, ensuring cooperation, honesty, and integrity in all aspects of their work. They will collaborate with international legal authorities to establish clear frameworks for managing the dissemination of information about potential extraterrestrial detections and comply with relevant laws and regulations. SETI practitioners shall cooperate in establishing and following ethical standards for the handling of any putative and/or confirmed detected evidence of extraterrestrial intelligence, including transparency and responsibility towards the global community.

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- **Expanded Preamble:** Sets the stage for future supporting documents, such as Best Practices and Codes of Conduct.

A Structured & Inclusive Consultation

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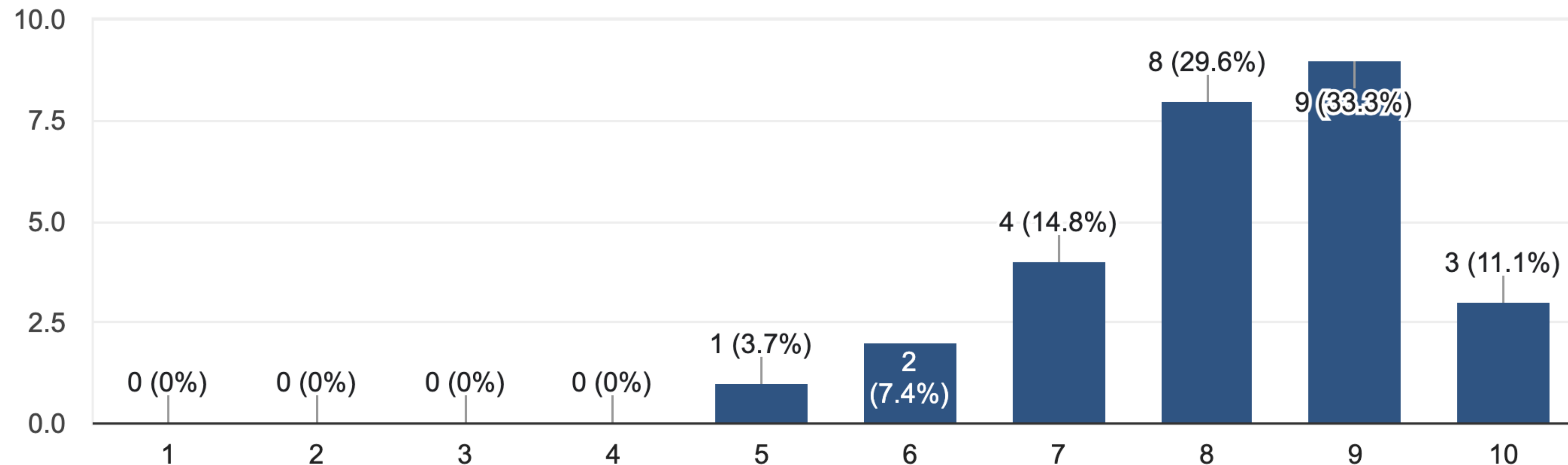
What the community said...

Strong overall support for the new draft:

- The feedback received from the wider community (15?+34 responses in total) was **Strongly Positive**.
- **Over 70% of respondents** rated their satisfaction with the draft at 8/10 or higher.

How satisfied are you with this draft document?

27 responses



Towards Formal Adoption & Endorsement

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- **IAA Endorsement (Early 2026):** The approved Declaration will be submitted to the IAA Board of Trustees for their endorsement.

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- **Formal Presentation (IAC 2026):** The newly adopted protocols will be formally presented at the IAC in Antalya, Türkiye.

And finally...

- **Thanks to everyone who has contributed to this process!**
 - The IAA SC Post-Detection Task Group (Kathryn, Carol & Les)
 - The IAA SC Membership & Executive
 - The Wider SETI Community...



Int. Academy of Astronautics
SETI Committee





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IAA SETI Committee Meeting

- All IAC participants interest in SETI are welcome!!!
- When? 1 October (Wednesday) 10.00-13.00
- Where ? Room E3.9